wasn’t bowling quickly, until one day, it just came out of me, as if it, too, was the most natural thing in the world. I began to understand how the body learns – by having information consistently fed to it, failure upon failure, micro improvements moving you towards your goal, before something clicks and it repeats back to me from memory the song I’d been teaching it.

The rest of the Trent Bridge Test is a real back-and-forth Ashes classic. We have them at 117-9 when Ashton Agar, their spinner on debut, arrives at the crease. We have been through all our plans before the game – the usual meticulous meetings on how to bowl at them, highlighting all their batting weaknesses. But when Agar starts to score runs with the kind of youthful freedom that only debuts occasionally hand to cricketers, nobody can remember our plan for him specifically. We start chasing his wicket a little bit, playing into his hands. He is eventually caught in the deep off the bowling of Stuart Broad for 98. As he walks off, smiling sheepishly and to a standing ovation, we have conceded a first innings deficit suddenly. It’s one of the first occasions I can remember in a long time where we have taken our foot off the gas slightly and not executed with the kind of ruthlessness we have been used to. By winter, these small windows of sessions within games will feel like warning signs to the inevitability of a team reaching breaking point, but we don’t see it then and just get back to working out how to wrest the order of things back in our favour.

In our batting reply, Agar is bowling to Broad with the game finely balanced. In a back room, I am receiving treatment from the physio when I hear a commotion, with others in the dressing room running out to see what has happened. Agar has bowled Broad a ball which has spun slightly out of the rough and angled into him, which he has edged to Brad Haddin, who then parries the ball to Michael Clarke at slip. Aleem Dar just stands there and doesn’t give it out. Broad doesn’t move either. It’s an Ashes moment that you know, as soon as it happens, won’t be a single, isolated moment, but instead carried down over time, pored over and enlarged, engulfing the act itself and turned into a moralistic issue. Personally, I think he has every right to stand there. I admire that he does this. However obvious it is, the umpire doesn’t give it out.

At the end of day four, Australia are 174-6. They require 310. Brad Haddin is still there – a really good player with deep competitive reserves and an ability to hit a good ball anywhere around the ground. We are the